FACILITATOR GUIDE · 60-MINUTE WORKSHOP

ChatGPT for Small Business

Your First Hour

Everything you need to run a warm, hands-on first session for small-business owners who are new to AI: timings, setup checks, room-reading cues, live troubleshooting, privacy guidance, and how to teach people to check what AI gives them.

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Portfolio sample by Chester M. Independent work prepared for a job application. Not official OpenAI material and not endorsed by OpenAI. Product features, plans and settings change often: confirm current availability before every session.

SECTION 1–2

Session at a glance

A first, confidence-building hour. Learners leave having finished one real piece of work for their business, and with a habit of checking AI output before it reaches a customer.

Audience	Small-business owners and staff who have never used ChatGPT or have only tried it casually. Mixed ages, mixed comfort with technology. No technical background assumed.
Format	In person (laptops, tablets or phones) or virtual (video call with breakout rooms). 60 minutes, more than half of it hands-on.
Group size	8–30 learners. Add one helper for every 10–12 learners in person; one breakout host per room virtually if possible.
Materials	Slide deck (15 slides, with speaker notes) · Participant Worksheet (4 pages) · visible timer · sticky notes with Wi-Fi details · this guide.
Learner prerequisites	A device with a current web browser or the app, and a way to sign in. Ask learners to create an account *before* the session; keep 5 minutes of buffer for those who could not.
Facilitator readiness	Has run every demo and Jam challenge in the same type of account learners will use within the last 7 days. (See the Community Trainer Readiness Kit for the full standard.)

Learning objectives

By the end of the session, learners will be able to:

Objective	How you'll see it in the room
1. Write a clear request that includes context, task, details and format for a real business task.	Learner's prompt includes at least three of the four parts (Jam rubric row 1).
2. Improve a draft using at least two follow-up messages in the same conversation.	Learner can point to a change a follow-up made (rubric row 2).
3. Verify an output using the four checks (facts, promises, fit and tone, fairness) and fix or remove anything they cannot confirm.	Learner names one thing they checked and how; pairs share a caught error (rubric row 3).
4. Protect private information by leaving customer and sensitive details out and using placeholders.	No customer names or contact details in prompts; placeholders used.
5. Decide where AI fits in their business, including at least one task they would not hand to it.	Answers to share-out question 3; written 7-day plan.

SECTION 3

Agenda and timings

Times are minutes from the start. If you fall behind, protect the Jam and the privacy and verification segment; shorten the basics and the share-out.

Time	Segment	Slides	Learners do	Facilitator moves
0–5	**Welcome**	1–3	Introduce their business at their table; open ChatGPT.	Collect business types at the door for demo examples. Quick hands-up on prior use to calibrate pace.
5–12	**The basics**	4–5	Listen; name one task they would like help with.	Set expectations: a fast first-draft partner, not an oracle. Keep the "how it works" explanation to one sentence.
12–19	**Try it: ask**	6–7	Write a four-part request for a real task (Worksheet p. 2).	Live demo with a learner's business. Circulate; hand starter prompts to anyone stuck.
19–25	**Try it: improve**	8	Send at least two follow-ups.	Model one follow-up live. Offer the self-critique stretch to fast finishers.
25–32	**Stay safe**	9–10	Spot the planted error in a demo draft.	Show where privacy and data settings are. Run the planted-error demo (Section 10).
32–49	**Mini Jam**	11–13	In pairs: pick a challenge, build, check, score (Worksheet p. 3–4).	Visible 15-minute timer; time calls at 10, 5, 1. Coach with questions, not answers.
49–55	**Share**	14	2–3 pairs share; celebrate caught errors.	Capture recurring confusion and product friction for your notes.
55–60	**Next steps**	15	Write Day 1 task; complete the exit check.	Point to the official help center for current feature and privacy details. Stay 10 minutes for questions.

Running short on time?

- Cut slide 4 to one minute: read the rule of thumb only.
- Do the follow-up demo and the planted-error demo on the same draft.
- Share-out: one pair only, chosen for a caught error.

Running long (90-minute version)?

- Run a second Jam round with partners swapped.
- Add a "build your prompt library" segment: each learner saves three reusable prompts.
- Extend Q&A with a parking-lot review.

SECTION 4

Setup and environment check

Most first-session problems are access problems. Test in the environment your learners will use, not only in your own account.

Free vs. paid features: what to check, not assume

> **ChatGPT's features, usage limits, available models and settings differ by plan and change often.** This guide deliberately does not list plan features or prices. Before each session, check the current official plan comparison and help center pages, and test every demo in the *lowest* account tier your learners are likely to have (usually a free account).

Design rule	Why it matters
Core activities use text chat only.	Typing a request and reading the reply works for everyone. The whole workshop can be completed this way.
Treat everything else as optional. File upload, web search, image creation, voice, saved memory, custom tools.	Availability and limits vary by plan, region, device and date. Demo them only as "you may see this," never as a step learners must complete.
Expect usage limits.	Learners on lower tiers may hit a message limit or be moved to a different model during a busy session. Pairing learners in the Jam halves the load.
Note the date you tested.	Write it on your run sheet. If more than 7 days pass before the next session, test again.

Checklist

7 days before

- [ ] Run all demos and all three Jam challenges in a free account and in any account type the host organization provides.
- [ ] Confirm the venue's Wi-Fi allows the ChatGPT site and app (some networks block AI tools).
- [ ] Send learners a sign-up reminder with a plain-language "how to create an account" link.
- [ ] Ask the host about accessibility needs and languages spoken.

1 day before

- [ ] Re-run the bakery demo; screenshot a good response as a backup.
- [ ] Print worksheets (plus large-print copies at 16 pt).
- [ ] Check the current location and wording of privacy and data settings so you can show them.
- [ ] Prepare a planted-error draft (Section 10).

30 minutes before

- [ ] Projector or screen share at 150% browser zoom; dark text on light background.
- [ ] Signed in on the presenter device, a fresh chat open, notifications off.
- [ ] Phone hotspot ready as a network backup.
- [ ] Timer, Wi-Fi notes, worksheets on tables.

Virtual add-ons

- [ ] Live captions turned on; links ready to paste in chat.
- [ ] Breakout rooms pre-assigned in pairs or threes.
- [ ] A co-host to watch the chat and help with sign-in.
- [ ] Worksheet available as a fillable or accessible digital file.

SECTION 5

Accessibility and inclusion

Small-business audiences vary widely in age, language, ability and comfort with technology. Build access in from the start.

Materials

- Slides use high-contrast text, large type (body 15 pt or more) and never rely on color alone.
- Worksheet uses a highly legible typeface; offer large-print and digital copies.
- Read aloud every prompt you type and every response you show.
- Describe any image or chart you show.

Delivery

- Use plain words. Say "a request" or "a message" before introducing "prompt."
- Allow learners to work on phones; demo on a phone once.
- Learners can type in the language they are most comfortable with; ChatGPT can respond in many languages. Remind them to apply the same checks.
- Voice input may help learners who find typing hard, where their device supports it.

Psychological safety for first-time users

Many beginners worry about "breaking it" or looking foolish. Normalize mistakes: "There are no wrong messages; if it doesn't help, you just ask again." Celebrate questions and caught errors more than polished output. Never single out someone who is struggling; pair them with a patient partner or sit beside them.

SECTION 6

Reading the room

Scan the room every few minutes, especially during practice. Look at screens and faces, not only at raised hands.

What you see or hear	What it may mean	What to do
Hands still, blank chat box, eyes on neighbors' screens	Not sure what to type	Hand over a starter prompt from Worksheet p. 2. Ask, "What's one email you wrote this week?"
More than a third of the room is stuck after 2 minutes	The demo moved too fast	Pause everyone. Co-write one prompt for a volunteer's business on screen, step by step.
Arms crossed, "this is all made up anyway"	Healthy skepticism, sometimes fear	Agree openly: "You're right to be cautious. That's what checking is for." Invite them to be the "editor" in their pair.
People finishing in 2 minutes and browsing elsewhere	Too easy for them	Give a stretch: three versions in different tones, or ask ChatGPT to critique its own draft.
Long silence after a question	Uncertainty, not disinterest	Count to seven. Then rephrase as a choice: "Hands up for A or B."
Someone types customer names or phone numbers	Hasn't thought about privacy yet	Quietly suggest a placeholder now; reinforce at slide 9 without naming them.
Virtual: cameras off, chat quiet	Low energy or unclear instructions	Ask for a one-word chat answer or a reaction. Repeat instructions in the chat.

SECTION 7

Adapting for beginners and advanced learners

Most rooms are mixed. Teach to the beginners and give experienced learners a richer version of the same activity rather than a different one.

Segment	Mostly first-time users	Mostly experienced users
Basics	Show where to type and how to start a new chat. Walk through one complete exchange slowly.	Skip the tour. Ask what they already use it for and what frustrates them.
Ask	Fill in the four parts on paper first, then type it.	Ask them to write the same request two ways and compare results.
Improve	One follow-up at a time, from the list on slide 8.	Have ChatGPT critique its own draft against their customer's likely questions, then revise.
Stay safe	Focus on placeholders and the four checks.	Discuss account settings, business policies and when to keep a human in the loop for customer-facing messages.
Jam	Challenge A or B. Use the starter prompt.	Challenge C plus the stretch goal; build a reusable prompt they could hand to a staff member.

Mixed rooms: three moves that work

1. **Pair across comfort levels** and give the experienced person the "editor" role so they coach rather than take over.
2. **Offer two tiers of every task:** the core version and a stretch version, both on the worksheet.
3. **Use experienced learners as examples** in the share-out, especially when they caught an error.

SECTION 8

Common live questions

Answer briefly and accurately. When the honest answer is "it depends on your account" or "I'm not sure," say so and point to the official help center. Never guess about pricing, data use or features.

Question	Suggested answer
"Is it free?"	"There is a free option and paid plans. What's included changes, so check the official pricing page for current details. Everything we do today works with typing in a basic account."
"Is it always right?"	"No. It can sound confident and still be wrong, which is why we check. You stay the decision-maker."
"What happens to what I type?"	"It depends on your account type and settings. Let's look at the data and privacy settings together; the official privacy policy and help center have the current answer. Either way, keep private customer details out."
"Why did my neighbor get a different answer?"	"Each response is generated fresh, so wording varies. That's normal. Judge it by whether it does the job."
"Can it post to my social media or send my emails?"	"In this workshop, you copy the text and post it yourself, after checking. Connecting tools to your accounts is a bigger topic for another session."
"Does it know my business?"	"Only what you tell it. That's why context in your request matters so much."
"Is using it cheating or fake?"	"Many owners use it like a helper who writes a first draft. Your knowledge, voice and final judgment are what make it yours. Be honest with customers where it matters to them."

SECTION 8, CONTINUED

Live troubleshooting

Problem	Quick fix	If that fails
Learner can't sign in or is stuck on account verification	Helper checks email or phone verification steps; try the browser instead of the app.	Pair them with a neighbor for now; follow up after the session.
Venue network blocks the site	Switch the presenter to a phone hotspot; learners use mobile data if willing.	Run the demo from your backup screenshots; learners draft prompts on paper and try them at home.

Problem	Quick fix	If that fails
"You've reached a limit" or similar message	Switch to the partner's device; keep working in pairs.	Explain that limits vary by plan and reset over time; check the help center for current details.
Response is cut off, off-topic or strange	Type "continue," or add the missing context and ask again. Use it as a teaching moment.	Start a new chat and paste a clearer request.
Learner sees a different screen layout or extra tools	Reassure them: layouts vary by device, plan and update. Focus on the message box.	Note it for your post-session report; update the deck if needed.
Projector or screen share fails	Narrate the demo while learners follow on their own devices.	Use printed worksheet steps; walk the room.

SECTION 9

Privacy guidance

Keep it practical and calm. The goal is a habit, not fear.

Say it this way

"Here's the simple habit: **if you wouldn't write it on a postcard, don't paste it.** Use 'a customer' or [NAME] instead, and fill in the real details yourself after you've checked the draft."

Leave out

- Customer names, phone numbers, emails, addresses, order numbers
- Payment card or bank details, passwords, account logins
- Health, legal, financial or other sensitive personal information
- Employee HR or performance details
- Confidential business information the owner would not want shared

Do instead

- Use placeholders: [CUSTOMER], [ORDER DATE], [AMOUNT]
- Describe situations in general terms
- Remove names from reviews before pasting them
- Review the account's data and privacy settings, and the business's own policies, before work use
- Delete a chat if something private was pasted by mistake

Facilitator note: data-handling options differ by account type and change over time. Show learners where the current settings are, and direct detailed questions to the official privacy policy and help center. Do not make promises about how data is stored or used.

SECTION 10

Teaching verification

Verification is the skill that keeps AI useful and safe. Teach it through a moment learners experience, not a warning they hear.

The planted-error demo (slide 10, 4 minutes)

1. **Set it up.** Ask ChatGPT for a holiday-hours announcement for the demo business *without* giving it the hours.
2. **Show the draft.** It will often fill the gap with plausible hours or details. If it asks for the hours instead, praise that and show your prepared backup draft with an invented detail.
3. **Ask the room:** "Would you post this? What's wrong?" Let learners find the made-up details.
4. **Name the lesson:** "When it doesn't know, it may guess. The fix is to give it the real facts, or delete the guess."
5. **Connect to the checklist** on Worksheet p. 4.

The four checks

Check	Ask yourself	How to confirm
Facts	Are names, dates, prices, hours, policies and numbers right?	Compare to your own records, website, menu or price list. Look up rules on official sources.
Promises	Does it offer anything I didn't approve, like a discount, refund, guarantee or delivery date?	Delete or change any promise you wouldn't make in person.
Fit and tone	Does it sound like me? Is it right for this customer and channel?	Read it aloud. Ask a follow-up to adjust tone or length.
Fairness	Is it respectful and inclusive? Would I be comfortable if it went public?	Remove stereotypes or assumptions about people; ask a colleague if unsure.

> **Higher-stakes topics need a qualified source**
> Taxes, legal requirements, permits, employment rules, health and safety, insurance and finance. ChatGPT can help learners understand terms and prepare questions; decisions should rest on official sources or a qualified professional.

Optional, for experienced learners: when a response includes sources or links, open them and confirm they say what the response claims. Availability of web search and citations depends on the account and settings.

SECTION 11

When to bring in a specialist

This is a beginner workshop. Recognizing what belongs in a deeper or more technical session is part of teaching well.

Handle in this workshop	Refer to a specialist or follow-up session
Writing, rewriting, summarizing and brainstorming with typed requests	Connecting ChatGPT to other business systems, APIs or automations
Basic privacy habits and where the settings are	Detailed compliance questions (for example, industry data rules) or contract and data-processing terms
Checking outputs against the business's own records	Legal, tax, financial or medical advice for the business
Simple reusable prompts; common sign-in help	Custom assistants, coding or agent workflows; billing disputes or account security incidents (route to official support)

How to refer without losing the learner

"That's a great question and a bigger topic than we can do justice to today. Let me take your details and connect you with [follow-up session or specialist]. For now, here's one thing you can try safely..." Log the question in your post-session notes so the program team can see demand for deeper content.

SECTION 12

Evidence of learning and follow-up

During the session

- Jam rubric scores (self-scored by pairs; collect a photo or count)
- Number of pairs who caught and fixed an error
- Prompts shared in chat (virtual)

Exit check (2 questions)

1. How confident are you using ChatGPT for a work task? (1–5)
2. What's one task you'll try this week?

Optional 7-day follow-up: "Did you use it? What happened?"

Post-session notes (5 minutes, same day)

Attendance and mix	Number, business types, prior experience
What worked	Moments of visible confidence or "aha"
Where learners got stuck	Steps, terms or screens that caused confusion
Product friction	Access, limits, layout changes or feature differences learners hit, plus questions referred to a specialist. Share recurring friction with the program team.
Changes for next time	One change to slides, worksheet or timing